

7. Special Abilities or Cards

The Cruellest Years is asymmetric by design. Every nation carries three signatures of its own: its starting dossier, its leader cards, and its Unique Unit Trait. The full register follows.

7.1 National Dossiers — Starting Statistics

Each nation enters the game with the following starting values.

European Powers

Note: "3 (2)" in the Cities row indicates 3 cities, of which 2 are in colonial holdings outside the metropolitan home territory.

Statistic	Germany	UK	France	Italy	Soviet	Poland	SE Eur.	N. Eur.	Iberian
Population	2	1	1	1	4	1	1	0	0
Treasury	24	31	28	14	22	1	2	1	5
Cities	3	3 (2)	3 (2)	2	4	2	1	3	2
Factories	5	3	2	2	4	2	3	0	1
Initial Weapons	5	5	5	2	5	1	1	1	1
Initial Units	3	3	3	3	3	2	1	1	1

Asian Powers

Statistic	China	Japan
Population	6	1
Treasury	3	9
Cities	5	2
Factories	1	3
Initial Weapons	1	3
Initial Units	5	3

The Wider World

Statistic	USA	S. America	S. Africa	Oceania	Mid. East	Br. India	Korea
Population	2	1	1	2	1	3	0
Treasury	66	1	1	2	3	3	0
Cities	3	1	1	1	1	3	1
Factories	6	2	1	1	1	1	1
Initial Weapons	5	1	1	1	1	1	0
Initial Units	3	1	1	1	1	1	0

Population is given in millions. Treasury is in standard gold units. Cities are placed on home territories at game start; factories may be built during play (see Section 6).

7.2 Military Unit Statistics

The Cruellest Years offers nine standard military units. National Unique Unit Traits (see 7.4) modify these base values.

Military Unit	Weap on	Pop.	HP	Rang e	Attac k	Spee d	Fee
Infantry	1	1	1	1	1	2	1
Mechanized Infantry	2	1	1	2	1	3	2
Artillery	2	1	1	2	2	1	2
Tank	4	1	3	2	2	2	4
Boat	3	1	2	1	2	2	3
Aircraft Carrier	3	3	6	1	1	2	6
Plane	4	1	2	3	2	3	3

Bomber	5	1	3	2	2	2	5
Anti-Aircraft Artillery	2	1	1	2	2	1	4

Fee is the per-turn maintenance cost in gold. A unit whose maintenance cannot be paid is removed from the board. HP is tracked by HP coins placed beneath the unit figure.

Aircraft Carriers may transport up to six land units across water in addition to launching Planes. Boats may transport land units equal to their Fee (3 units).

7.3 Leader Cards

Each nation has between one and three named historical leaders. At game start, each player chooses one leader to govern with for the entire campaign. The choice is binding except through specific event cards.

Each leader's ability is tagged Passive (always active), Active (declared on a turn, may have a cost and cooldown), or Hybrid (a permanent effect plus an activatable component).

Germany

Adolf Hitler (Führer) — Total War [**Passive**]

Every 4 Factories you control produce +1 extra weapon per turn.

Paul von Hindenburg (Reichspräsident) — War Bond [**Hybrid**]

Passive: Your starting cities produce +1 treasury per turn. Active: When training any unit, pay 4 gold to reduce its weapon cost by 1.

Unique Unit Trait: Tiger Tank's Blitzkrieg

Passive: All German Tanks gain +1 Attack and +1 HP but cost +1 Weapon (5W / 4HP / 3A).
Active (Cooldown 6): Pay 2 gold per chosen Tank to give those Tanks +2 Speed for one turn.

United Kingdom

Winston Churchill (Prime Minister) — Never Surrender [**Active**]

Cost: 1 gold. When one of your military units is being attacked, flip a coin. On heads, damage is reduced by 1. May be triggered multiple times against a single attack. No cooldown.

Neville Chamberlain (Prime Minister) — Appeasement [**Passive**]

If you did not attack any enemy unit this turn, gain +5 gold and +1 weapon at end of turn.

Unique Unit Trait: Sea Surface Minelayers

All British Boats gain +2 Attack and lose 1 HP (3W / 1HP / 4A). Devastating but fragile.

France

Charles de Gaulle (Leader of Free France) — Free France [**Passive**]

Cities you control outside metropolitan French territory (i.e., your colonial cities) produce +3 treasury per turn.

Édouard Daladier (Prime Minister) — Rearmament Program [**Passive**]

Your Factories produce +1 weapon every 2 turns (i.e., +1 weapon on even-numbered turns).

Albert Lebrun (President) — Republican Guard [**Active**]

Cost: 2 gold. Choose one Tank in your starting territory. It and all adjacent friendly Tanks gain +2 HP. Cooldown: 12 turns.

Unique Unit Trait: Char B1 Heavy Tank

All French Tanks gain +1 HP (4W / 4HP / 2A).

Italy

Benito Mussolini (Duce) — Battle for Grain [**Active**]

Training cost of a single Mechanized Infantry is reduced by 1 Population. Cooldown: 1 turn.

Victor Emmanuel III (King) — Royal Decree [**Active**]

Cost: 3 weapons, 2 population. Choose one Mechanized Infantry. Create two additional Mechanized Infantry adjacent to it. Cooldown: 8 turns.

Unique Unit Trait: Bersaglieri Motorized Infantry

All Italian Mechanized Infantry gain +1 Speed and pay 1 less Fee per turn (2W / 1HP / 1A / Speed 4 / Fee 1).

Soviet Union

Joseph Stalin (General Secretary) — Collectivization [**Passive**]

On even-numbered turns, your cities produce +2 extra gold.

Vyacheslav Molotov (Foreign Minister) — Non-Aggression Pact [**Active**]

Cost: 5 gold. Choose one enemy unit. It cannot attack your units this turn. Cooldown: 5 turns.

Unique Unit Trait: T-34 Tank

All Soviet Tanks cost 1 fewer Weapon to train (3W / 3HP / 2A). The most cost-efficient tank in the game.

Poland

Władysław Sikorski (Prime Minister in Exile) — Government-in-Exile [**Passive**]

Whenever an enemy unit enters your territory, gain +1 treasury.

Ignacy Mościcki (President) — Emergency Conscription [**Active**]

Cost: 2 gold. Choose one city in your starting territory. Each adjacent enemy unit takes 1 damage. Cooldown: 5 turns.

Unique Unit Trait: Armia Krajowa

All Polish Infantry stationed in Polish territory gain +1 HP and pay 1 less Fee per turn (1W / 2HP / 1A / Fee 0).

Southeastern Europe

Josip Broz Tito (Partisan Leader) — Brotherhood and Unity [**Passive**]

When an enemy unit is destroyed in your territory (by any cause), flip a coin. On tails, gain +1 weapon.

King Michael I (King of Romania) — Royal Coup [**Active**]

Cost: 2 gold. Choose one enemy unit adjacent to your Infantry. It takes 1 damage and cannot move during its owner's next turn. Cooldown: 7 turns.

Unique Unit Trait: Partisan Fighter

All Southeastern Infantry gain +1 Speed and pay 1 less Fee per turn (1W / 1HP / 1A / Speed 3 / Fee 0).

Northern Europe

King Haakon VII (King of Norway) — Government in Exile [**Passive**]

For every city captured from you by another power, you gain +1 population and +3 gold per turn. You may move your capital city with one of your military units.

Risto Ryti (President of Finland) — Winter War Diplomacy [**Passive**]

If you control fewer cities than any adjacent player, your cities produce +1 treasury per turn.

Unique Unit Trait: Ski Trooper

All Northern European Mechanized Infantry pay +2 Population but -2 Weapon to train (0W / 3P / 1HP / 1A). Useful when weapons are scarce.

Iberian Peninsula

Francisco Franco (Caudillo of Spain) — Nationalist Consolidation [**Passive**]

+2 population per turn.

António de Oliveira Salazar (Prime Minister of Portugal) — Neutrality Act [**Passive**]

If you did not attack any unit this turn, gain +2 weapons.

Unique Unit Trait: Tercio Legionnaire

All Iberian Mechanized Infantry cost +1 Weapon and gain +1 HP and +1 Attack (3W / 2HP / 2A).

China

Mao Zedong (Chairman of the Chinese Communist Party) — Battle of Chishui River [**Active**]

All Chinese Infantry and Mechanized Infantry gain +1 Speed for 1 turn. Cooldown: 2 turns.

Chiang Kai-shek (KMT Generalissimo) — Nationalist Conscription [**Passive**]

When you train Infantry, flip a coin. On heads, gain 2 gold.

Unique Unit Trait: Guerrilla Infantry

All Chinese Infantry cost 1 less Weapon and gain +1 Speed (0W / 1HP / 1A / Speed 3). The cheapest, fastest infantry in the game.

Japan

Emperor Hirohito (Emperor of Japan) — Imperial Rescript [**Passive**]

Once per turn, when one of your units is destroyed, flip a coin. On heads, the enemy unit that destroyed it takes 1 damage.

Unique Unit Trait: MXY-7 Sakura

Once per turn, you may choose any number of Japanese Planes to gain +1 Attack for the attack — but each Plane so chosen crashes (is destroyed) immediately after its attack resolves.

United States

Franklin D. Roosevelt (President) — Arsenal of Democracy [**Hybrid**]

Passive: +1 weapon and +3 gold per turn. Active: When training a unit, pay +1 gold to skip its 1-turn training time.

Harry S. Truman (Vice President / President) — Truman Doctrine [**Active**]

Cost: 5 gold. Choose up to 2 allied players. Each gains +2 gold and +1 weapon. Cooldown: 5 turns.

Unique Unit Trait: Trench-Gun Infantry

All American Infantry gain +1 Attack (1W / 1HP / 2A). The deadliest standard infantry in the game.

South America

Getúlio Vargas (President of Brazil) — Import Substitution [**Passive**]

Once per turn, your Mechanized Infantry and Tanks cost 1 less Weapon to train, but their Fee is +3 gold for as long as they remain on the board.

Juan Perón (President of Argentina) — Justicialist Rally [**Active**]

Cost: 3 gold. Choose one city. It produces +2 population next turn. If an enemy unit is adjacent to that city, it produces +2 weapons instead. Cooldown: 4 turns.

Unique Unit Trait: Gauchos

South American Mechanized Infantry in South American territory gain +1 Attack, +1 Speed, and cost +1 Weapon (3W / 1HP / 2A / Speed 4).

South Africa

J.B.M. Hertzog (Prime Minister of the Union) — Union Defence [**Passive**]

All Infantry in your territory gain +1 Attack on odd-numbered turns.

Haile Selassie (Emperor of Ethiopia) — League of Nations Appeal [**Active**]

Cost: 2 gold. Choose one enemy unit adjacent to your Infantry. It takes 1 damage and its Attack is reduced by 1 until your next turn. Cooldown: 4 turns.

Unique Unit Trait: Askari Corps

All South African Infantry gain +1 HP and pay 1 less Fee per turn (1W / 2HP / 1A / Fee 0).

Oceania

John Curtin (Prime Minister of Australia) — Pacific Pact [**Passive**]

All friendly Boats (your own and your allies') gain +1 Speed on odd-numbered turns.

Peter Fraser (Prime Minister of New Zealand) — Island Hopping Coordination [**Active**]

Cost: 3 gold. Choose one Infantry. It gains +1 Attack and +1 HP for every friendly military unit adjacent to it. Cooldown: 10 turns.

Unique Unit Trait: Diggers

Oceanian Infantry in Oceanian territory gain +1 Attack, +1 HP, and pay +1 Fee per turn (1W / 2HP / 2A / Fee 2). Pricey but tough on home soil.

Middle East

Mustafa Kemal Atatürk (President of Turkey) — Kemalist Reforms [**Passive**]

+1 population per turn. Infantry that complete training gain +1 Attack on the turn they finish training.

Reza Shah Pahlavi (Shah of Iran) — Persian Oil Concessions [**Active**]

Cost: discard 1 weapon. Gain +10 gold. Cooldown: 1 turn.

Unique Unit Trait: Desert Cavalry

All Middle Eastern Mechanized Infantry in Middle Eastern territory cost 1 less Weapon and gain +1 Speed (1W / 1HP / 1A / Speed 4).

British India

Lord Linlithgow (Viceroy of India) — Imperial Mobilization [**Passive**]

(In development.) Provisional: Your cities produce +1 weapon per turn in addition to their normal output.

Subhas Chandra Bose (Indian National Army Leader) — Azad Hind [**Active**]

(In development.) Provisional: Cost 3 gold. Convert one enemy Infantry adjacent to your territory into a friendly Infantry. Cooldown: 8 turns.

Unique Unit Trait: Gurkha Rifles

(In development.) Provisional: All British Indian Infantry gain +1 Attack in mountainous and jungle terrain.

Korea

Kim Gu (President, Korean Provisional Government) — Resistance Network [**Passive**]

(In development.) Provisional: While Korean territory is occupied by another power, the occupying power loses 1 gold per Korean territory it controls each turn.

Syngman Rhee (Korean Independence Activist) — Diplomatic Appeal **[Active]**

(In development.) Provisional: Cost 2 gold. Choose one allied Great Power. It gains +1 weapon per turn for 3 turns. Cooldown: 6 turns.

Unique Unit Trait: Korean Liberation Army

(In development.) Provisional: Korean Infantry cost 0 Weapon to train (only 1 Population) but have only 1 HP and 1 Attack.

Several leader abilities listed here are visibly stronger than others — most notably Persian Oil Concessions, Arsenal of Democracy, and the long-cooldown Island Hopping Coordination. These values are open to playtest revision and should be considered provisional. The British Indian and Korean cards are explicitly marked as in development.

7.4 Agendas, Policies & Historical Plans (Optional, In Development)

Beyond leader cards and unit traits, each nation will hold three Agenda cards representing the deliberate strategic doctrines of its wartime leadership (e.g., Germany's Blitzkrieg, the Soviet Scorched Earth, America's Lend-Lease). The full deck of 48 cards (3 cards × 16 nations) is in development.

Each card lists a cost (in gold, weapons, population, or units), an effect that resolves immediately or persists for a stated number of turns, and a cooldown. Some cards have prerequisite conditions (e.g., "must be at war with a Great Power").

Provisional examples include:

- Germany — Blitzkrieg. Cost: 1 gold per German Tank. All German Tanks gain +2 Speed for one turn. Cooldown: 6 turns.
- Soviet Union — Scorched Earth. Cost: 5 gold. Destroy all improvements in one of your territories to deny them to an invader. Cooldown: 8 turns.
- United States — Lend-Lease. Cost: 15 gold. Gift 10 weapons or 10 treasury to an allied player. Cooldown: 4 turns.
- Japan — Bushidō Charge. Cost: free. All Japanese Infantry +2 Attack for one turn; −1 HP next turn. Cooldown: 6 turns.
- China — Long March. Cost: free. Move any number of friendly units 2 tiles toward the interior without combat penalty. Cooldown: 10 turns.

7.5 Chronicle of War — Historical Events (Optional, In Development)

An optional Historical Events Deck reflects the real calendar of the war — events that altered alliances, opened fronts, or forced decisions. Some events fire automatically on their historical date; others must be played by a commander whose prerequisite conditions have been met.

The deck treats three events as Hinges of History — moments where a different choice could have changed the rest of the war:

- The German–Soviet Non-Aggression Pact (August 1939).
- Germany invades the Soviet Union (June 1941).
- Japan attacks Pearl Harbor (December 1941).

7.6 The Two Chinas Special Rule

China occupies a unique political position in this period — a fragile coalition between the Nationalist government (KMT) under Chiang Kai-shek and the Communist resistance under Mao Zedong, both fighting Japan and each other. China may be played in three modes by agreement of the table:

- **Unified China** — A single player commands all Chinese resources. Both leader cards (Mao and Chiang) are available to that one player.
- **United Front** — Two players share China cooperatively. Both have full decision rights; treasury and unit pool are shared. Disagreements on major actions are resolved by die roll.
- **Civil Truce** — The dossier splits 60/40 between Nationalist (KMT) and Communist (CCP). The two Chinese players may cooperate, betray, or remain in armed truce while jointly facing Japan.